

The California Fruit Tree Planting Guide

A fruit tree is a twenty-year decision made in about twenty minutes at the nursery. Most backyard fruit trees fail for one of two reasons: the variety never had enough winter chill to fruit here, or the tree was planted too deep. Both are decided before you ever pick up a pruner.

Start with chill hours, not with the photo on the tag

Deciduous fruit trees need a set number of winter hours below 45°F to flower and fruit. Without it, UC notes, trees leaf out late, blossoms drop, and few flowers form. No flowers, no fruit. Coastal stations run low: UC measures El Cerrito at 191 hours a year and Santa Barbara at 186, while warmer inland valleys accumulate 400 to over 1,000. Mild spells also cancel chill you have already banked, and a warm January afternoon is normal here.

Fruit	Chill hours needed	On the foggy coast
Citrus	None. Not a chill crop.	Reliable
Fig	No chill figure given	Reliable
Persimmon	No chill figure given	Reliable
Apple	500 to 1,000+ (UC IPM cites 1,200 to 1,500 to fully satisfy)	Only as a named low-chill variety
Pear	600 to 800	Marginal. Better inland
Peach, nectarine	600 (low-chill) to 900	Marginal. Better inland
Apricot	600 to 900	Marginal. Better inland
Sweet cherry	800 to 1,200	Hardest of all here

Chill figures: UC IPM. UC has not published a chill-hour average for Santa Cruz County, so be skeptical of any number that claims one. Check the CIMIS station nearest you (De Laveaga in Santa Cruz, Watsonville West), then read the chill requirement on the variety tag. The variety decides this, not the species.

Low-chill apples that work

UC names these as needing under 300 hours: **Anna, Dorsett Golden, Beverly Hills, Gordon, Tropical Beauty,** and **Ein Shemer**, which needs no chill at all.

For figs in cool coastal gardens, UC recommends **White Genoa**.

For low-chill peaches and apricots, the popular variety names come from nurseries, not UC. Trust the chill number on the tag over the name.

Will it fruit alone?

- **Self-fruitful, plant one:** citrus, fig (common types), persimmon, pomegranate, apricot, peach, nectarine.
- **Usually needs a partner:** most apples, pears, plums, and sweet cherries.
- A pollinizer should sit within about 50 feet. Treat 100 feet as the outside limit.

Planting: wide, shallow, and high

- **Plant bare-root from December through March**, while the tree is dormant and the rain is doing the watering. Get it in the ground within a few days of buying it.
- **Dig wide, not deep.** Two to three times as wide as the roots spread, never deeper than the longest root. Set the tree on a small cone of native soil and fan the roots over it.
- **Keep the graft union 2 to 4 inches above the finished soil line**, so the tree sits slightly high on a gentle mound.
- **Backfill with plain native soil.** UC research found that amending the planting hole is not beneficial. You want roots to leave the hole, not circle inside a pocket of rich soil.
- **Do not fertilize at planting.** Wait until the tree has a year of growth behind it.
- **Skip the stake** unless the site is windy or the tree is top-heavy. If you do stake, remove it before a year is out.
- **Water 3 to 10 gallons a week** through the first year, adjusting for soil, weather, and mulch. Mulch 3 to 6 inches deep, pulled back clear of the trunk, and keep drip emitters off the crown.

The three mistakes that kill backyard fruit trees

1. **Planting too deep.** UC calls burying the crown the number one cause of tree failure. The cruel part is the delay: the tree can look fine for 5 to 15 years, then decline. Plant it high and keep the crown dry.
2. **Amending the planting hole.** It feels generous and it backfires. Improve the whole bed before planting, or use native soil and nothing else.
3. **Buying on impulse.** Big-box and online stock is shipped for many climate zones at once. A gorgeous cherry tree is still a bad idea in a fog-belt yard. Check the chill number before you check the price.

Which fruit tree actually produces here?

Variety guides by microclimate, chill-hour explainers, bare-root timing, and pruning, all for Santa Cruz County, at

ambitiousharvest.com/learn

Sources: UC IPM, UC Master Gardener programs (Contra Costa, Sonoma, Alameda, Stanislaus, San Luis Obispo), UC Cooperative Extension. Verified July 2026.